

COACHING INSTITUTES

Ranchi | JHARKHAND



The swot factory

Driven sons and daughters of middle India, they put themselves through the wringer of preparatory classes to beat the odds in competitive exams

■ By Sharda Ugra

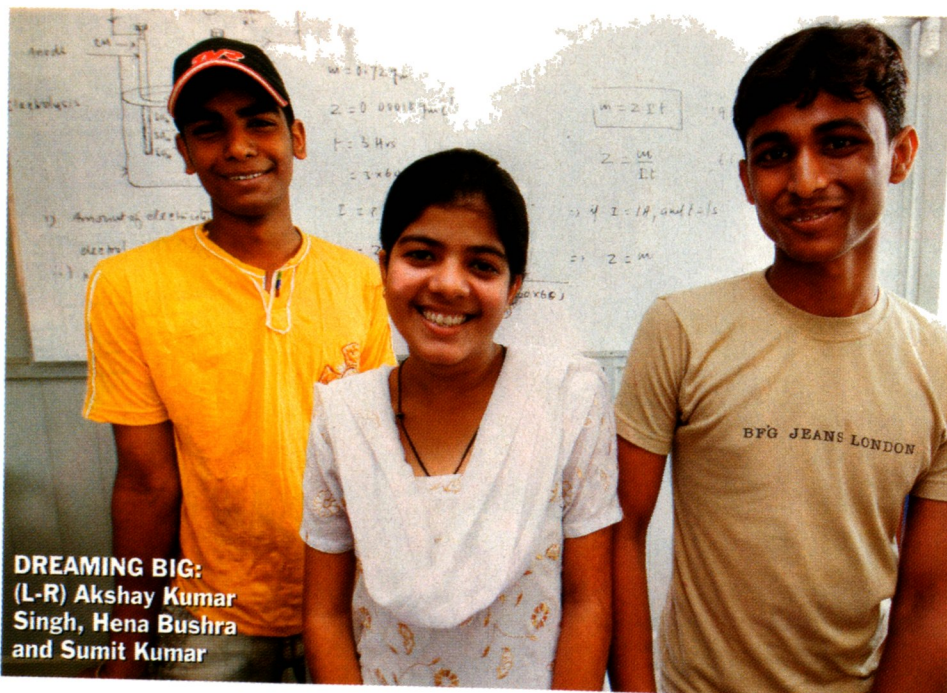
Hena Bushra knows what she wants. To understand the mysteries of the human brain. It means waking up at 4 a.m. and putting in school work, tuitions and six hours of studying. Sometimes she imagines driving a Scooty, swooping through the streets, free, footloose, 16, just like in the hoardings on her way to her coaching classes. "But there's a time for everything," she says, "and this is the time to study." Bushra is one of the 300 students at the Max Foundation, one of Ranchi's many coaching institutes that prepare students for competitive exams. Max calls itself

for the IIT entrance exams. The eldest son of an LIC agent, Kumar, 17, thinks he can make it. Is he really that clever? Kumar's reply beats his smile by a full second. Yes. It is astonishing, such unshakeable confidence. It is probably the fuel that helps thousands like Bushra and Kumar through daily schedules that could make Spartans weep. Bushra lives at home, but like Kumar, Akshay Kumar Singh, 18, left the security of a family business in Barhi 125 km away. He lives in a lodge and when there is a bucketful of clothes to wash and dreadful tiffin from the community mess, he thinks, "*Yaar, kahan aa gaye*"? All to become Tom Cruise. Not Cruise the movie star, but the fighter pilot of *Top Gun*. Despite a disapproving family, Kumar has gone after his dream like a Sukhoi would its quarry. Tuitions at Max, more tuitions for the Air Force exam, maths classes and fitness training.

These are not hedonistic, mall crawlers but the driven sons and daughters of middle class India, who feel the financial weight their parents bear for their ambition. Kumar treats himself to a movie only once a month, on a break Bushra reads fiction. Irfan Alam, faculty for physics and one of Max's eight teachers, says no one walks in merely to kill time, the dropout rate is low and

courses are getting tougher. "We try to be sympathetic, not dictator-like, because as it is, things are tough for these kids," Alam says.

When their plans materialised, is the West an end destination? Silicon Valley? A neurology practice in New York for Bushra? She's sure she would be homesick and Singh anyway has pinned his faith on the nation state. Kumar contemplates the idea, nods his head and then shakes it. "I just want to get out of Ranchi, actually," he says.



DREAMING BIG:
(L-R) Akshay Kumar Singh, Hena Bushra and Sumit Kumar

RAVI S SAHANI

■ MORE THAN FOUR LAKH STUDENTS APPLY TO THE IITs EVERY YEAR AND ONLY 3,000 GET THROUGH

■ THERE ARE 262 MEDICAL COLLEGES IN INDIA WHICH PRODUCE 29,172 DOCTORS EVERY YEAR

an academy for science studies and analysis. It is two doors down from a similar centre called the Science Connection and a short drive away from the Hari Om building which houses national giants FIITJEE and dozens of similar boot camps for the young. Except inside their crammed classrooms, it is as if students want to be put through the wringer.

"Labour is a must," declares Sumit Kumar. He has left home in Samastipur only to enroll in classes in Ranchi to prepare him